

Lesson 8

Acceptance (Part 2) - How to Practice Acceptance in Real Moments

In the last lesson, we talked about acceptance and what it is and what it isn't. This one is about what it actually looks like when you're in the thick of it. When you wake up and your symptoms are flaring or your mind is screaming, or when things just feel really messy. Remember, acceptance is putting down the mental fight.

It's your relationship to the situation. It's what's left when you stop resisting. But before we go any further, I want to make a distinction about thoughts because we're going to talk about thoughts in this lesson and we're going to talk about thoughts when we get to allowing, and they're different.

Acceptance deals with the thoughts about your situation. This is the broader picture. These are the resistance thoughts, the ones that are arguing with your reality and fighting against where you are. They sound like this shouldn't be happening, or I should be further along, or this shouldn't have happened to me.

Those are the thoughts we're addressing here. They're not about moment to moment sensations. They are about your situation as a whole and they keep the mental fight alive. When we get to allowing, we're gonna talk about a different category of thoughts. The ones that spike in the moment when a sensation shows up, the catastrophizing what ifs, the looping, those get handled differently and we will get there.

For now, we're focused on resistance to your situation. So what does acceptance actually look like? What do you do with these thoughts when they show up? First of all, I wanna be careful here because I'm not trying to give you affirmations or a script to tell yourself. We're not trying to convince you of anything.

We're not trying to put a positive spin on what you're feeling, and we're definitely not falling into self reassurance just to escape whatever is happening for you right now. Acceptance is not really about what you're telling yourself. It has way more to do with the thinking that you choose to stop engaging with the mental dialogue, the arguing with your situation, the.

This shouldn't be happening. It will quiet in time, but first, you have to stop feeding it. The goal at this stage is not to talk to your brain or to calm yourself down with your thinking. Most of this work is about non-engagement with the resistance thinking. You're not replacing them with better thoughts.

You're not arguing back. You're just leaving them alone. Resistance doesn't always look super obvious. It's not always going to be you freaking out or clearly fighting what's going on. It can come across a bit more subtle, so I want you to be staying aware for these things so you don't miss them.

Resistance can look like using acceptance to monitor even more. So if you find yourself thinking, is this working? Is this making it better? Are things getting worse? Am I doing this right? And caring about whether it does any of those things. That is still resistance. You've just dressed it up as acceptance if you are mentally negotiating.

Alright, I'm accepting this. Will it go away now? Is it going away or watching yourself very carefully to see if anything's changing? That's not acceptance either. If you are accepting just so that you can feel better, that's still resistance. You're still doing it with an agenda. You might notice yourself doing this.

There's a loud dialogue going on in your head, and it sounds like you're arguing with your thoughts. You're freaking out internally, but you're going, this is fine. It's okay that this is here. I accept this. I accept this situation. This is fine. If that sounds frantic, if it sounds like you're trying to convince yourself if you can feel the force and the urgency underneath it, that is not acceptance.

That is just you trying to talk yourself into something and your nervous system is always gonna know the difference there. Here's the thing, if you are trying to accept, you're still doing something. It's still a project you're working on and most likely trying to get an A on. You're trying to do acceptance, but actually accepting is more like giving up the project, giving up the fight, giving up this need to fix and giving up the belief that there is even something to fix right now.

You get to a point where you just stop trying to get somewhere. You stop trying to make something happen, you just stop. That's the hardest part of all of this. I am asking you more than anything. To just stop, not give up, not roll over. Stop. So what do you actually do when you catch yourself? When you notice that you are in the fight, when you notice you're in resistance, you're arguing with your situation, spinning on why this is happening mentally, going through all the reasons this shouldn't be your life.

You don't need to do anything fancy. You just stop engaging. You might say to yourself, this is what's here today, and then turn your attention back to whatever you were doing. You come back to today to whatever is actually in front of you. When you catch yourself fighting again, 10 minutes later, you do the same thing.

No judgment. You just stop again and again and again. It can help to just focus on today like nothing is getting fixed today. You're not figuring anything out today. You're not solving your situation today. Your only job is to handle today as best as you can. I'm not figuring anything out today. I'm just living today and that was huge for me.

Taking the timeline from forever down to just to today, not this week, not this month, not when will this nightmare ever end. Just today. Something I really want you to remember and revisit. When you are living in a high state of sensitization, your thinking is not reliable. Your thoughts are going to be very

scary.

They're going to be urgent. They're going to feel very true and very important, but they're being driven by the sensitization itself. The alarm state is generating alarming thoughts. That's literally what it does. So when a thought shows up telling you this shouldn't be happening or that you should be further along.

Or that you need to figure out how to solve this. You don't have to believe it just because it's loud. You do not have to engage with it just because it showed up. You can just leave it alone and you're going to need to practice doing that. One of the main reasons this stuff doesn't just pass through is because we keep putting our grubby little hands into it.

We keep messing with it, picking it up, turning it over, trying to figure it out, trying to solve it, trying to think your way through it. Stop, leave it alone. Acceptance is the ability to stay in your life, in your day without adding any additional commentary or suffering on top of what's already here. The situation is what it is.

You don't have to keep arguing with it, and I wanna take the pressure off here. Acceptance does not require you to feel good. You're not gonna feel good. You're not gonna feel calm, you're not gonna be a hundred percent sure of anything. You are not going to feel ready and prepared. You do not need to believe 100% that everything is going to be okay, because actually real acceptance requires the opposite.

It requires you to be willing to not know. Not knowing which way this is going to go or how long it's going to take, or if you're doing it right, and the most important thing with all of that is being willing to keep going anyway. Regardless of not having any of those answers, it's normal to not feel certain.

You shouldn't be a fan of what you're experiencing right now. I understand that you wish that things were different. You can hold all of that and still practice acceptance. Those things are gonna come up by themselves. You can still feel terrified and decide on purpose to stop fighting your situation.

Acceptance will come and go. Some moments are going to feel easier, and some moments you're going to forget entirely because that fearful sensitized part of your brain will take over and you'll find yourself right back in the fight, spinning, resisting, and arguing with your reality. And when that happens, you have to remind yourself, you are not starting over.

You haven't lost any of your previous progress, because it really feels that way. Nothing is ruined. Your job is to pick right back up where you left off, notice that you're fighting again. Stop the fighting and come back to today. Every time you do that, every time you notice the resistance, you put it down even briefly.

You are rewiring something. You're teaching your nervous system that you do not have to stay in the fight, that you have the ability to step out of it, that you have that power. You're not trying to be perfect at this. You're just making the choice over and over whenever you remember to do not try to force

yourself into acceptance.

This won't work. You cannot force your way there. The focus is to stop doing things that keep you out of acceptance and then let time pass clear weeks. An amazing doctor from the sixties who wrote the book, *Hope and Help for Your Nerves*, which is a must read. Talks about the importance of letting time pass when you have a sensitized nervous system.

And it's a piece that a lot of people miss. They want to do something to make acceptance happen faster, but your job is to create the conditions for acceptance by stepping back, giving it space, and most importantly, giving it time. You'll know this is working when you realize, hmm. I haven't been arguing with my situation lately.

I haven't been spinning on why this is all happening and how to stop it, and you didn't do anything special to make that shift. You didn't force it to happen. You just stopped fighting. Please don't underestimate the power of stopping the fight. Stop putting your hands into it. Let time pass. It is something that will settle on its own.

That's when you start to trust that this does take care of itself. When you get out of the way, acceptance removes the mental fight. It's that internal mental softening toward your situation that makes everything else possible. But there is another layer to this work, and that is what you do with the physical experience of these symptoms and sensations, what you do with the moment to moment experience in your body, the fear.

The thoughts, the symptoms that really do a great job of grabbing your attention because you can accept your situation mentally and still be physically fighting in your body. You can stop arguing with reality and still be bracing against every sensation that shows up and that's where allowing comes in.

In the next lesson, I wanna talk about what allowing actually is how it is different from acceptance and why you need both.